

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 517

By Williams

A RESOLUTION to honor Captain Barry "Butch" Wilmore upon his pioneering career with the U.S. Navy and NASA.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly take great pleasure in recognizing a native Tennessean who has evinced the true spirit of the Volunteer State while making invaluable contributions to America's space flight program; and

WHEREAS, Barry Eugene "Butch" Wilmore (U.S. Navy, Retired) is a decorated NASA astronaut and veteran of three spaceflights; he has accumulated a total of 464 days in space, including more than nine months aboard the International Space Station; and

WHEREAS, Captain Wilmore was first selected as an astronaut in 2000 and had participated in two earlier spaceflights when, in June 2024, he and fellow astronaut Captain Suni Williams were launched into space as part of the historic first crewed flight of the Boeing Starliner; unexpected technical challenges led to the Starliner returning to Earth unmanned and caused their mission to stretch into a 286-day stay in space; and

WHEREAS, only five U.S. astronauts in the history of the space flight program have spent more consecutive days in space on a single mission than Captain Wilmore; and

WHEREAS, Captain Wilmore did not waver despite the difficulties inherent in this mission, inspiring the country and the world through his strength and preparedness in the face of unthinkable challenges; and

WHEREAS, while in space, he remained closely connected to his beloved Tennessee, participating in two video calls with his alma mater, Tennessee Technological University, and serving as a guest announcer for the Grand Ole Opry; and

WHEREAS, a graduate of the United States Naval Test Pilot School, Captain Wilmore has proudly served his country as a Navy officer and aviator, completing twenty-one combat

missions during Operation Desert Storm; he has accumulated more than 8,000 flight hours and 663 carrier landings, all in tactical jet aircraft; and

WHEREAS, Butch Wilmore's courage and tenacity were forged from his early days as a student at Tennessee Technological University, where he earned both a bachelor's degree and a master's degree in electrical engineering and was a walk-on student athlete for the Golden Eagles football team; and

WHEREAS, in 2018, he received the NCAA's highest honor, the Theodore Roosevelt Award; to date, he remains the only recipient of the award from the Ohio Valley Conference; and

WHEREAS, Butch Wilmore was inducted into the Tennessee Tech Sports Hall of Fame in 2003, received the university's Outstanding Alumni Award in 2010, and was awarded an honorary doctorate in 2012; and

WHEREAS, he has served his alma mater with distinction as a member of the Tennessee Tech Board of Trustees since 2017, a role to which he was confirmed twice without opposition by the General Assembly; and

WHEREAS, born in Murfreesboro, Butch Wilmore grew up in Mt. Juliet, where his parents, Eugene and Faye Wilmore, still reside; he is a proud alumnus of Mt. Juliet High School; and

WHEREAS, Captain Wilmore is a devout Christian, and his faith in Jesus Christ sustained him through the trial and uncertainty of his space mission until his safe return to Earth on March 18, 2025, on a SpaceX Dragon capsule; and

WHEREAS, his sacrifices to advance the cause of human discovery have also been shared by his family, including his wife, Deanna, and daughters, Daryn and Logan, to whom all Tennesseans owe a debt a gratitude; and

WHEREAS, Captain Butch Wilmore is to be greatly commended for his dedication to duty in the face of adversity; this brave astronaut served an extended stay in space without complaint or compunction, and he is worthy of our approbation; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor Captain Barry "Butch" Wilmore upon his pioneering career with the U.S. Navy and NASA, welcome him home after an extended space mission, thank him for his ongoing commitment to space exploration, and wish him all the best in his future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.